

Hortonville Men's College Soccer Recruiting Blueprint

Updated October 4, 2026.

For HHS players and their parents looking at men's college soccer. Rules can change. Confirm the requirements that apply to you with the school.

Contents

- Start here
- Introduction
- Section 1: Choose a school you want to attend
- Section 2: How to select schools worth a closer look
- Section 3: Understand the college soccer pathways
- Section 4: Research schools and programs
- Section 5: Academics, admission and eligibility
- Section 6: Know when coaches can recruit
- Section 7: Build your player evidence
- Section 8: Contact coaches authentically
- Section 9: Evaluate interest, camps and visits
- Section 10: Understand offers and real costs
- Section 11: Make the decision and prepare
- Appendices

Start here

You don't need to read this whole guide tonight. Start with the introduction and Sections 1-3. Try the HHS fit check on the site's College Recruiting page, or use Section 1's worksheet, then bring your notes to us.

Already talking with coaches? Jump to Sections 8-9. Got an offer? Go to Section 10 with a parent. Rules and eligibility questions live in Sections 5-6.

The AI prompts are optional help. The program directory is a lookup list, and its contact refresh is still in progress. Neither is required reading from top to bottom.

Introduction

HHS players, if you want to keep playing after high school, this is for you. Parents, it's for you too. You don't need to know the rules or have a college list yet. We'll work through it together.

Let's get one thing out of the way: college soccer isn't given. You need to be a very good player for the team you're trying to join. If you're not one of the stronger players on your team and haven't tested yourself against strong competition, don't count on a competitive varsity spot right now. Get an honest assessment from us or your club coach. Keep your goals, but build a plan around where your game actually is. Recruiting work matters. Improving your game matters more.

For most of you, college will be the highest level you play. That's a good goal. The education needs to matter long after soccer ends. Start with a school you'd want to attend, then figure out how soccer fits.

Coaches are recruiting to improve their teams. Schools want students, and recruiting companies want customers. Encouraging words don't always mean someone's watched you play. We'll help you sort real interest from a sales pitch without assuming everyone's out to fool you.

Players, take the lead. Parents can help with costs and big decisions. We can help you assess your game and ask better questions. Use Google, AI if you want, and actual conversations. Go see the school when you can. No tool replaces that work.

How to use this guide

Start with Sections 1-3 to work out what you want and which paths to explore. Section 4 digs into the team. Sections 5-6 cover school requirements and recruiting rules. Sections 7-9 help you get seen and talk with coaches. Sections 10-11 cover the offer and your decision.

Read the part you need now. Come back when the next step matters. The AI prompts and school directory are references, not more chapters to read straight through.

Section 1: Choose a school you want to attend

Start with the school

Here's the anchor question: **If soccer didn't work out, would you still want to attend this school?**

You'll take classes there, live there and pay for it. An injury or a change of plans doesn't erase the bill. If soccer's the only thing you like, know that before you commit.

Some of you will say, "Coach, I just want to play." That's fine to say. Be honest about the trade-offs, including what you'll study and what your family can afford.

Figure out what matters to you

You may know exactly what you want to study. You may have no idea yet. Both are reasonable places to start in high school.

Think about the classes you enjoy and the kinds of work that interest you. Check the school's actual programs. If you're undecided, find out how it helps students choose a major and what happens if you change your mind.

Think about daily life, too. Would you be comfortable several hours from home? Would you enjoy the campus and surrounding town? A school that's right for your teammate may not be right for you.

Have the money conversation with your family early. Talk about what you can afford each year and how much borrowing everyone is comfortable with. Parents, be clear about those limits before your player gets attached to a school. Don't assume soccer will pay for college. We'll cover financial aid and actual costs later.

Also think about what you want from soccer. Would you be happy training if you rarely played? Would you consider a reserve team? Ask your coach for an honest assessment of your current game. Later sections will help you look into what a program actually offers.

Write down your answers:

Question	Your notes
What might I want to study?	
What would make me want to attend without soccer?	
What have we agreed about cost and borrowing?	
How far from home am I comfortable going?	
What soccer experience am I hoping for?	
What compromises am I willing to make?	

Mark what you won't compromise on. Keep the rest open while you learn.

Google It Tip

Pick a school and spend time on its official website. Search "[school name] undergraduate majors" and "[school name] net price calculator." The calculator estimates what a family might pay after grants and scholarships; it isn't an offer. Read the actual pages rather than relying on search summaries.

AI Tool Tip

AI is optional. If you use it, try this:

I'm a high school student looking at colleges where I might play men's soccer. Interview me one question at a time about what I want to study, our budget, how far from home I'd go, and what I want from soccer (varsity, reserve or club). Then sort my answers into must-haves, preferences, dealbreakers and unknowns, and point out where they conflict. Flag what my parents or coach need to weigh in on. Don't guess my playing level or suggest schools yet. When we're done, turn it into a one-page worksheet I can share, including whether I'd attend each kind of school without soccer.

Make sure the result reflects your own thinking. For school research, request official links and open them yourself.

Go see for yourself

When a school becomes a serious possibility, visit if you can. Take the admissions tour and look at where you'd live and study. If travel isn't practical yet, start with a virtual tour and a conversation with admissions.

Arrange soccer staff meetings in advance because recruiting rules vary. We'll cover those rules and the questions to ask on a visit later. For now, decide what you want from the school before getting caught up in the recruiting pitch.

Section 2: How to select schools worth a closer look

Start with your priorities

Use the answers you wrote in Section 1 to build a starting list. Include schools you're curious about and schools your coach thinks are worth investigating. You don't need a perfect list yet.

Check the school before getting carried away with its soccer program. Does it offer subjects you want to study? Would you want to live there? Is there a reasonable path to making it affordable? If you don't know, write down the question and find out.

Keep ambitious options on the list, but give attention to programs that appear to match your current game. Ask your coach why they recommend a program and what evidence supports that assessment. "You should be able to play somewhere" isn't specific enough to build a useful list.

Look beyond the division name. We'll explain the different pathways in the next section. For now, use the school and the actual program as the basis for your research.

Don't let your inbox choose your college

An email can introduce you to a school you hadn't considered. It doesn't show that the school is a good fit or that the coach wants you on the team.

Colleges send admissions messages to encourage applications. Programs and camp organizers send invitations to fill camps. Those messages can be useful, but you need to understand their purpose before spending money or changing your college plans.

Read what the message actually says. Does it explain how the coach knows about you? Does it refer to your play, or does it just use your name? Is the next step a conversation about your game, or a link to register and pay?

Read the message before buying the pitch

Message	What you actually know
University brochure or general email	The school wants applications. You haven't learned anything about soccer interest.
Camp invitation or a message that only adds your name	You're on a mailing list. Ask whether the coach has watched you before spending money.
Coach talks about a specific match or part of your game	There's something real to discuss. Ask what else they need to see.
Ongoing talk about your position and entering year	You're being considered. Ask about the next step. There's still no offer unless they make one.

Ask, "Have you evaluated me? What did you watch?" A friendly reply isn't a held spot. Section 8 covers keeping the conversation going, and Section 10 covers actual offers.

Keep a simple comparison

For each school, record why it interests you, what you know about the academic fit and estimated cost, and what remains unanswered. Record the soccer contact separately: who contacted you, what they've evaluated, and the next step they actually proposed.

You can use a notebook or a spreadsheet. Keep facts separate from your impressions. "Coach watched my full match and requested a call" is a fact you can record. "Coach sounded excited, so I'll probably start" is an assumption.

As you learn more, remove schools that don't meet your priorities and add others worth investigating. You aren't trying to collect the most emails. You're trying to find worthwhile options.

Do you need a recruiting service?

If your family can afford one and finds the help useful, have at it. Ask who you'll work with, what they actually do and what happens if you cancel. Having a person to call can be valuable.

You can also do this work yourself. The school information and published contacts are out there. It takes effort, but you can research teams, share your film and talk directly with coaches.

My concern is the sales pitch. Paying for a package doesn't prove a college coach wants you. Ask who's watched you play and whether they'll give you an answer you might not like. Use us and your club coach for the human side of the process. Whichever route you take, stay involved. This is your college decision.

Google It Tip

Search the school's official academic pages and men's soccer website. Check that the coach's name and role match the staff directory. Look up the program's recent results and roster. If an invitation involves a paid camp, read the camp page to see who operates it and which staff are expected to attend.

AI Tool Tip

Help me evaluate this recruiting message. Separate specific evidence that the coach has evaluated me from general promotional language. Identify whether it concerns admissions, a camp, a soccer evaluation or an offer. Explain what remains unknown and suggest useful follow-up questions. Don't assign a probability of being recruited or assume a roster spot. I'll remove personal contact details before pasting the message.

Use the result to prepare your questions. The coach's answers and your own research will tell you more than AI guessing at their intentions.

Go see for yourself

Once a school earns a place on your serious list, arrange a visit if practical. Look at the school as a student would. If a coach meeting is permitted and arranged, ask about the recruiting conversation you've already had. Try to speak with current players in different roles. We'll cover those questions in the visit section.

Section 3: Understand the college soccer pathways

There's more than one way to keep playing

You'll hear a lot about divisions when you start looking at college soccer. Learn what they mean, but don't let the label make the decision for you.

The NCAA, NAIA and NJCAA are separate organizations that govern college sports. Their rules differ. Club soccer is another option at many schools, separate from the varsity program.

Look at the actual school and team. A division name won't tell you whether you can earn a place there, how much you'd play or what your family would pay.

College soccer isn't for everyone

Wanting to keep playing doesn't mean varsity college soccer will be the right fit. You need to consider the level of play and whether you want the commitment that comes with it. You may decide you'd rather put that time into other parts of college life. That's a valid choice.

The NCAA's published men's soccer estimates give some perspective:

High school participants	NCAA participants	Estimated NCAA participation	D1	D2	D3
484,908	28,746	5.9%	1.4%	1.7%	2.8%

Source: [NCAA, Probability of Competing Beyond High School](#), using 2024-25 participation data; checked October 4, 2026.

These are national estimates comparing high school and college participation totals, not a prediction of your personal chances. The NCAA assumes roughly comparable roster turnover rather than tracking each high school player into college. The figures cover NCAA soccer, not NAIA, junior college or college club opportunities. They also don't measure scholarships or playing time.

Take the numbers as a reason to assess your options honestly. Ask your coach for specific feedback and keep researching. You can decide varsity soccer is worth pursuing, or choose another way to keep playing. Choosing a school you like and playing club soccer isn't a failure.

NCAA Division I

D1 is often the first goal players mention. For most high school players, it's a reach. Being a good starter on your school team isn't enough evidence that you're ready. You should be standing out against strong competition and showing that your game holds up when the pace increases. High-level club soccer can provide that competition and exposure, but a club name alone doesn't show your level, and it's not a universal requirement for every recruit.

Before building your search around D1, ask your coach which specific programs your current game fits and why. If the evidence isn't there, put your main effort into other options while you work on improving.

D1 scholarship and roster rules have changed. The school's funding and available places matter more than a headline. Section 10 covers the rules and the questions to ask.

Wisconsin has four D1 men's programs: [UW-Madison](#), [UW-Milwaukee](#), [UW-Green Bay](#) and [Marquette](#). All are worth watching. Don't assume a Wisconsin school recruits mostly Wisconsin players. Look at several years of rosters under the current coach. How many new players came from in-state, and where did they play before college? Section 4 walks you through that research. A pattern gives you something useful to ask about; it doesn't tell you whether the coach wants you.

NCAA Division II

D2 deserves serious consideration. Don't assume you'll walk onto a team because it isn't D1. Research the players and ask your coach how your game compares.

For Wisconsin players, geography also matters. [UW-Parkside is Wisconsin's only NCAA Division II school](#). If D2 is your goal, be prepared to look beyond the state and decide how far from home you'd actually attend college.

Look at each program's recruiting reach. You may be competing for a place with international recruits and college transfers as well as other high school players. Read player biographies to understand their previous competition and experience. Where someone comes from doesn't show their ability or tell you whether the coach would recruit you. Compare players in your position and ask what the program needs for your graduating class.

D2 programs can split athletic aid among players. Don't build a budget around the maximum allowed. Section 10 shows how to compare the actual package.

NCAA Division III

D3 schools can't award athletic scholarships, but that doesn't mean there's no scholarship money. Many offer academic scholarships and need-based grants. At some schools, your work outside soccer can open up awards for community service or other interests. Keep your grades up and make room for something you care about beyond the field. Those things can give you more schools to choose from and more ways to pay for them.

Be clear about what you're being offered. A D3 school can't award aid because you play soccer, even if someone calls it an "academic" scholarship. Athletic ability or participation can't be part of the school's award criteria. Ask financial aid what each award is based on and what you'll need to do to keep it. [NCAA D3 financial aid rules](#).

D3 is also a serious soccer option. The absence of athletic scholarships doesn't tell you how strong a team is or whether you could make it. If the school fits your academic interests, look into the program with the same care you'd give any other team.

For many players reading this guide, D3 deserves more attention than a search built around D1. Wisconsin has public university options as well as private colleges. The [WIAA men's soccer page](#) is a starting point for UW-Eau Claire, UW-Whitewater, UW-Platteville, UW-Stevens Point, UW-River Falls and UW-Stout Polytechnic. [UW-Superior also has men's soccer](#), playing in the Upper Midwest Athletic Conference alongside Minnesota schools.

Compare private and public schools after aid

Wisconsin's public D3 schools deserve a good look, especially if you're a Wisconsin resident. Their starting prices can be lower. But don't cross private schools off your list because of the sticker price. Academic scholarships and need-based grants can change the picture quite a bit.

Here's a comparison of **average annual net price after grants and scholarships**, using the same federal reporting year for both groups. It covers the 13 private and seven public Wisconsin schools with NCAA D3 men's soccer in our comparison, excluding closed Northland College.

Wisconsin D3 men's soccer schools	Average annual net price, 2022-23	Average four-year graduation rate, 2017 entering cohort
Private schools	\$25,238	52.3%
Public schools, using resident tuition	\$14,750	35.6%

These are our simple averages of each school's figures from [NCES IPEDS financial aid data](#) and [graduation data](#), checked October 2026. Net price includes tuition and living-cost allowances after grants and scholarships, not loans. It describes full-time first-year students receiving that aid, not specifically soccer players. Living arrangements and family circumstances vary. Graduation rates describe first-time, full-time bachelor's students graduating at their original school. Each school gets equal weight in these averages.

The private-school group has a higher four-year graduation rate. That's worth asking about. Finishing in four years instead of five can change the total cost and let you start working sooner. It doesn't prove that private schools cause better outcomes or that every private school has a higher rate. Ask each school about your major's course schedule, advising and graduation rates. Compare the cost of finishing the degree, not just one year's bill.

Your family's price could be well above or below these averages. Use each school's net price calculator, then compare written aid offers. A private school can end up being your better deal. A public school can too. Section 10 walks through that comparison.

Date note: Published tuition and cost references in this guide are for 2026-27 where stated, checked October 2026. The net-price averages above are historical 2022-23 figures, and the graduation figures follow an earlier cohort. They aren't 2026-27 prices or predictions of your costs.

Looking beyond Wisconsin

Don't stop at the state line. The [MIAC in Minnesota](#) has strong D3 men's soccer options worth watching. Most private colleges use the same published undergraduate tuition regardless of your home state. That means a Wisconsin student usually doesn't face the out-of-state tuition increase you'd see at a public university. For example, [Macalester publishes one undergraduate tuition schedule](#).

That doesn't mean tuition stays fixed for four years or that everyone's aid package is the same. Check the school's rates and aid rules, and include the cost of getting home. The school still needs to fit you.

NAIA

NAIA is a separate college sports association. Its schools can offer athletic aid, with program funding and individual awards varying by school. Qualifying academic aid may be treated differently under its team aid rules. We'll cover those details in the financial section.

Give these schools a fair look. Ask about the degree programs and actual cost. On the soccer side, clarify whether the opportunity is with the varsity team or a reserve program. A large recruiting class doesn't tell you how many players will get meaningful match time.

NAIA programs vary considerably. Some may be realistic options for your current game; others may recruit players well beyond your level. Watch the actual team and research its roster before deciding that NAIA means an easier place to play.

Viterbo University in La Crosse is Wisconsin's only NAIA men's soccer option. There are more programs to look into in Illinois and Indiana. NAIA schools are generally private, and those private schools typically don't charge different tuition based on your home state. That can make an out-of-state search more attractive. Some NAIA schools are public, though, so check each school's rates and compare costs after aid rather than assuming the label settles it.

Junior college

Junior college, often called JUCO, usually means starting at a two-year college. NJCAA is a major association for junior college sports, but it doesn't govern every two-year program. It has its own divisions; NJCAA D1 is different from NCAA D1.

This can be a worthwhile starting point for a player who wants a two-year academic program or plans to transfer. Don't treat it as a guaranteed route to a four-year soccer team. Look into the first school on its own merits.

Some junior college programs may offer a more accessible roster opportunity, but the quality of soccer and the student experience varies significantly. A strong JUCO team can be very difficult to make. Ask whether the opportunity means a place in training, a match roster or a realistic chance to earn minutes. Getting onto a team is only useful if the school and academic plan also work for you.

Madison College is a nearby program worth watching. Its men's team won the 2025 Region 4 Division II championship and reached the NJCAA national tournament for the first time. That's a good reminder that junior college doesn't mean easy soccer. I'm not as familiar with Wisconsin's JUCO programs, so we'll need to look into those together.

If transferring is your plan, ask early which courses will count toward your intended degree at the destination school. Admission and eligibility to compete are separate questions. A coach's suggestion that you could transfer later isn't a commitment from another college.

College club soccer

Club soccer can let you attend the school you want and keep competing without joining its varsity team. Some clubs play in regional leagues and national tournaments. This is different from intramural soccer, which generally involves teams competing within the same school.

Don't assume joining a club is automatic or that every club offers the same experience. Check tryouts and roster limits. Ask about practice expectations, travel costs and membership dues. Find out how many matches were actually played recently and who runs the team.

If your preferred school doesn't offer a realistic varsity opportunity, its club program may still be worth investigating.

Your grades matter at every level

Don't let recruiting become an excuse to let school slide. Strong grades help with admission and can qualify you for academic aid wherever you play. At D1 and D2 schools, academic money may reduce how much athletic money the program needs to offer to make your costs manageable. That can matter to a coach working within a budget.

It's especially useful in D2's partial-scholarship model, where men's soccer has a maximum of [9.0 full-scholarship equivalents](#). [D2 counts athletic aid toward its team limit](#). Academic aid awarded without considering athletic ability is different. Ask financial aid and compliance to confirm how your awards are classified and whether they can stack. It doesn't mean the coach will automatically offer you more athletic money. D1's rules have changed, but its budgets haven't become unlimited. Section 10 explains the differences.

What's your best fit?

Use the HHS fit check on the site's College Recruiting page with your family, then bring the results to us. Away from the site, use Section 1's worksheet or the school-fit interview in the AI appendix. It'll help you sort school priorities, what you want from soccer and what still needs an answer. You can print it or download your notes.

It won't label you a "D2 player" or tell you your chances. We need to watch your game for that conversation, and each college coach decides who fits their program. You don't have to pick one division for your whole search.

Google It Tip

Search "[school name] men's soccer" and "[school name] men's club soccer." Use official school pages to confirm which programs exist and which association governs varsity soccer. For club information, look under campus recreation or student organizations as well as athletics.

AI Tool Tip

Help me compare men's soccer options at the schools on my list, including varsity and club. Verify each program's current association and division using official sources. For Wisconsin D1 schools, compare up to three recruiting classes under the current coach, using only the years that coach has been there: identify in-state recruits, their previous clubs and any transfers, using published biographies rather than guessing nationality from names. Flag missing information. Compare annual costs for the same academic year and living arrangement, separating tuition and fees from housing, food and other expenses. Use my Wisconsin residency where applicable. Identify published academic and need-based aid, renewal rules and whether awards can stack; don't treat advertised awards as my confirmed aid or subtract loans as discounts. Explain the findings in plain language, link and date your sources, and give me questions for admissions, financial

aid and the coach. Don't rank my chances or assume division tells you team quality. Refer detailed playing-time research to Section 4.

Go see for yourself

When practical, watch a college match and think about the pace and demands of the game. Ask your coach what you should notice. On a campus visit, learn about the soccer option you'd actually pursue, including club if that interests you.

Keep the school at the center of your decision. The right pathway is the one that fits your education and the soccer experience you want at a cost you understand.

Source notes

Rules checked October 4, 2026. Detailed eligibility, contact dates and offer terms belong in later sections.

- D1: [NCAA House settlement guidance](#) and [current D1 manual, bylaw 17.2](#).
- D2: [NCAA scholarship guidance and limits](#).
- D3: [current NCAA D3 manual, financial aid bylaws](#).
- NAIA: [official financial aid guidance](#).
- Junior college: [NJCAA sports and divisions](#) and [NCAA transfer guidance](#).
- Club: [NIRSA collegiate club soccer](#) and [club league information](#).

Section 4: Research schools and programs

You've got a starting list and some coach feedback. Now find out what those teams actually do. This is where watching games and checking who plays will tell you more than a recruiting pitch.

Start with the school, then look into the team

You've already thought about school fit. Now look beyond the brochure. Read the department requirements for your intended major. Ask whether admission to the major is separate and what happens if you change your mind. If your degree leads to a license, check whether that program meets the requirements for the license you want.

Find out how labs, internships or clinical placements work with soccer travel. "We make it work" sounds good. A conversation with an adviser and a player in that major will tell you more. Ask about a real student's schedule.

Read the coach's background. Look at several seasons of results and the level of the opponents. A big win total doesn't explain how the team plays or how its players develop. It's one part of the picture.

Ask what the pitch means

I'd rather you ask an awkward question now than get surprised after moving in. "We can see you helping us" sounds good. Helping how? Varsity, reserves or a tryout? What have they watched that makes them see a role for you?

The staff's needs may differ from yours. Use the evidence below to check whether the opportunity they're describing makes sense.

Nothing beats watching the game

Watch full-match footage. Highlights show moments a program wants you to see. A match shows what players have to do between those moments.

Every school plays differently. Your club may build patiently through midfield while a college wants the ball forward quickly. You might play winger in both places and still have a very different job. Watch how the team builds attacks, where it presses and what happens after losing possession. Then follow your position without watching only the ball.

Does that player receive under pressure? Run behind defenders? Win aerial balls? Cover a lot of ground defensively? How does the role compare with yours?

Watch more than one match if you can. Protecting a lead can look different from chasing a goal. Write down dates and timestamps, then review them with your coach. A different style can be something you learn. You still need to understand the adjustment and whether your strengths fit what the college asks.

Who is on the roster, and who actually plays?

A 35-player roster isn't 35 playing opportunities. Look at several box scores, including close matches. Check starts, appearances and published minutes. Getting on for the last two minutes is different from being part of the regular rotation.

Pay attention to your position and to freshmen. How many freshmen appeared? How many started? Was that under the current coach? Are the players ahead of you expected back? A graduating senior doesn't necessarily leave an opening for you.

Transfers belong in this discussion. Your competition may include players who have already trained and competed in college. Ask what incoming transfers the staff expects at your position. Counting only returning players and high school recruits can leave out an important part of the plan. Ask about documented experience and age where available, rather than assuming every transfer is older.

Roster composition deserves a hard look. If 75% of a roster consists of documented international recruits, that suggests overseas recruiting is central to how the team is built. Next, check who gets the starts and minutes. If those recruits also make up most of the playing group at your position, take that seriously when evaluating an invitation.

I'd want a specific answer about how recent recruits directly from U.S. high schools have been used. Were they contributors or mainly extra names on the roster? What makes the coach see a useful role for you?

This is about opportunity and experience, not treating a passport as a measure of ability. Read the actual biographies and prior teams. Some players may arrive with considerably more experience than you. A freshman label doesn't show age. A hometown doesn't show citizenship, recruitment background or scholarship support. Those details need evidence. But missing scholarship information is no reason to ignore a clear pattern in who is recruited and who plays.

If the international players aren't playing, your conclusion changes. Follow the match evidence rather than deciding the answer from the roster alone.

Reserves need actual games

If reserves are part of the pitch, ask for the schedule. How many games were scheduled this season? How many were actually played? A future fixture isn't a completed match, and a canceled game doesn't help a player develop.

Ask who coaches reserves, how they train and how players earn a varsity look. Regular coaching and meaningful matches can make a reserve opportunity worthwhile. A large group training all year with little competition is a different proposition.

If the staff says you'll sit out or "redshirt," ask compliance what that means under the rules applying to you. NCAA D1/D2 eligibility changed in 2026, and an old explanation about saving a season may not fit your entering class. Section 5 explains that issue. The important questions here are what you'll do, when you might compete and whether the plan is worthwhile to you.

Talk to the players who don't start

I want you to hear from more than the players the staff puts at the front of the visit. Ask to talk with a nonstarter, preferably without a coach directing the conversation. Be respectful. You're learning about their experience, not fishing for a complaint.

Did their role match what they expected? Do they get useful feedback? Do reserves really play? Would they choose the school again? Compare several accounts. One happy starter or unhappy reserve doesn't speak for

everybody.

Keep the evidence together

What you're checking	Evidence worth saving
Academic fit	Department requirements and adviser answers
Playing standard and style	Full matches, timestamps and your coach's assessment
Opportunity at your position	Roster, match records and incoming-player questions
Freshman and recruit backgrounds	Current-coach seasons, biographies and actual participation
Reserve opportunity	Completed results, canceled games and coaching arrangements
School fit without soccer	Your campus experience and unresolved concerns

Google It Tip

Search the school's official roster, player bios, season stats and match records. Look for full-match streams or replays. Save the season and coach you checked. Old pages can look current in search results.

AI Tool Tip

Look at freshmen in [school] men's soccer over the last [3] completed seasons, and note if the head coach changed. From official rosters and stats, show rostered freshmen, those who appeared, those who started and published minutes. Give counts and source links. Missing minutes are unknown, not zero. Break out [my position] if supported. End with questions for the coach.

The AI prompt appendix has separate, shorter tasks for roster backgrounds, substitutions, playing style and reserves. Start with a few accessible matches rather than asking for the coach's entire career at once.

Go see for yourself

Watch a match in person when practical. Take your coach's questions with you. Then spend time at the school as a future student. You're investigating both places you'd spend your time.

Section 5: Academics, admission and eligibility

I know you came here for soccer. This part can still end the conversation before the soccer matters. Being wanted by a coach doesn't mean you've been admitted or cleared to compete.

Know which question you're asking

Admission is whether the school accepts you. Athletic eligibility is whether you meet the rules to participate. Your major may have another application or grade requirement. Aid can have its own conditions. When we say "compliance," we mean the college staff who check the sports rules and whether you can play.

Get your school counselor involved early. Tell them the pathways you're considering. A class counting toward high school graduation isn't automatically an NCAA-approved core course. Your transcript GPA may differ from the GPA the NCAA uses.

NCAA academic requirements

For D1 and D2, the Eligibility Center certifies academic and athletics eligibility. Basic academic requirements include graduation and 16 approved core-course credits. D1 requires a 2.3 core-course GPA and D2 a 2.2. D1 also has the 10/7 requirement: 10 approved core courses before senior year, including seven in English, math or science. Work through the required subjects with your counselor rather than checking only the total. [NCAA initial eligibility](#), [current D1 manual](#), [current D2 manual](#).

SAT and ACT scores are no longer required for NCAA D1/D2 initial eligibility for students first enrolling full time on or after August 1, 2023. The school or an academic scholarship can still have testing requirements. Check both. D3 schools set their own academic standards; international D3 prospects have an Eligibility Center athletics-certification requirement. [NCAA eligibility guidance](#).

Those are minimum participation requirements. They're not a promise of admission, especially at a selective school.

NAIA and junior college

NAIA uses PlayNAIA to determine eligibility. Current guidance includes a final high school GPA route of 2.3 or higher and an alternative route with additional criteria. The older explanation that everyone must meet two out of three requirements is incomplete. [NAIA high school guidance](#), [NAIA freshman eligibility](#).

For junior college, ask which association governs the program. Not every two-year school belongs to NJCAA. Admissions and the school's rules staff should explain the requirements that apply to you. [NJCAA resources](#).

If transferring is the plan, involve the destination school before picking courses. A credit can count at your first school and fail to move you toward the degree you want at the next one. Admission, transferable credits and athletic eligibility are separate questions. A headline about a 2.0 transfer GPA isn't a complete transfer plan.

Gap years, age and playing history

Before taking a gap year to keep playing, get the eligibility consequences checked. Tell compliance about previous full-time college enrollment, academy or professional-team involvement, compensation and your

playing history. Being associated with an academy is a detail to disclose, not an automatic finding that you're ineligible.

The NCAA's current D1/D2 guidance describes a continuous five-year eligibility period tied to initial full-time enrollment or the start of the regular academic year after your 19th birthday, whichever comes first. For the age trigger, a birthday before September 1 points to the immediately following academic year; a birthday on or after September 1 points to the subsequent academic year. Have compliance calculate your start date. It doesn't pause just because you sit out. Prospects initially enrolling in 2026-27 can be reviewed under the previous or new framework, whichever benefits them; fall 2027 entrants and later use the new framework. Delaying enrollment can reduce available time. [NCAA age-based eligibility guidance](#).

That's why "redshirt for a year and save a season" is no longer safe as universal D1/D2 advice. Have compliance explain your dates and applicable model. Other associations have their own rules. A plan that works for a teammate may not work for you.

Make a deadline sheet

List application deadlines, scholarship priority dates, transcript requests and eligibility tasks. Include the major's requirements. Ask who is responsible for each step. A coach may help arrange an admissions review, but get the conditions and next steps from admissions.

Keep your grades up after committing. Finish final transcripts and certification. It would be a rough way to lose an opportunity you worked for.

Google It Tip

Use official admissions and department pages for your entering year. Check approved courses with your counselor. For a gap year or transfer, bring your actual history to compliance instead of relying on a general search answer.

AI Tool Tip

I graduate in [year] and am looking at [schools]. Make a checklist separating admission, my major, athletic eligibility and scholarship deadlines. List each task, due date, responsible person and official source. Ask about previous enrollment or gap-year plans. Explain where core GPA differs from transcript GPA. Leave the final eligibility decision to my counselor and school compliance.

Go see for yourself

On a visit, meet an academic adviser. Ask what your first year would look like and which courses must be taken in sequence. The coach's plan and the degree plan should work together.

Section 6: Know when coaches can recruit

You can start learning about schools before a coach can do every type of recruiting with you. The part that confuses families is that the rules change by division and by activity. An email and an off-campus meeting aren't the same thing.

The dates below apply to high school men's soccer prospects in 2026-27. Transfers need separate guidance.

NCAA contact and visits

Activity	D1	D2	D3
Coach recruiting calls, emails and texts	June 15 after sophomore year	Any time	Any time
Off-campus in-person recruiting	August 1 before junior year	June 15 before junior year	After completing sophomore year
Official visit	August 1 before junior year	June 15 before junior year	January 1 of junior year
Unofficial recruiting visit	Athletics involvement from August 1 before junior year	Any time	Any time

Sources: [D1 manual](#), [2026-27 D2 recruiting guide](#), [D3 manual](#).

The school pays for some or all of an official visit. With an unofficial visit, the family generally pays. An ordinary admissions tour is different from a visit involving athletics recruiting. Ask before scheduling the coach into your plans.

Yes, D3 coaches can call or email you at any point in high school. There are still dates for other activities. D2 calls and electronic communication are also permitted at any time under the change effective in 2024. Older articles can get that wrong.

Check the date before buying tickets

Age permission is only part of the answer. A recruiting calendar can restrict an otherwise permitted visit.

D1 men's soccer has dead periods November 9-12 and December 11-14, 2026. These generally prevent in-person recruiting and recruiting visits, not otherwise permitted calls and emails. There's a limited College Cup event exception. Let the host school confirm the activity. [Official D1 calendar](#).

D1 men's soccer also has a quiet period December 23-25. Off-campus in-person recruiting isn't allowed then. Confirm any campus plans with the school. [D1 manual, bylaw 13.17.14.3.3](#).

D2 has a separate calendar. Check the [official D2 calendar](#) rather than borrowing D1 dates.

A camp isn't a workaround. Under the current D1 men's soccer provision, recruiting conversations at institutional camps and clinics start August 1 before junior year. Instruction and camp logistics are separate. Some summaries still give June 15 for these conversations. [D1 manual, bylaw 13.12.1.5.1](#).

NAIA and junior college

NAIA has no NCAA-style high school communication calendar. You can have direct conversations throughout high school. Its campus tryouts are limited to two days per prospect at each institution, with conditions on expenses. No calendar restriction doesn't mean the school has no deadlines. [NAIA guidance](#), [tryout interpretation](#).

For a junior college opportunity, have its compliance contact identify the applicable association and current visit or tryout requirements. The NJCAA handbook is available through [official resources](#).

You can keep moving

Prepare your profile, watch matches and learn about schools while waiting for a permitted conversation. For a younger player, a lack of D1 response may reflect the rules. For an older player, it may mean something else. Section 8 covers silence without trying to read a coach's mind.

If a plan is unclear, ask compliance. You don't need to become an expert in every bylaw, but you do need the right answer for what you're about to do.

Google It Tip

Search the official association rules and the calendar for the academic year of your activity. Confirm the men's soccer division. Check the date on the document, not just the search result.

AI Tool Tip

Can a men's soccer coach at [school] [activity] on [date] with a student graduating in [year]? Verify the program's division and that year's official rules and calendar. Cite the specific provision and flag conflicting summaries. Separate high school and transfer rules. Give me a short question for compliance to confirm before I arrange it.

Go see for yourself

You can still explore a campus as a student. Before including athletics staff or a recruiting activity, have the school confirm what is allowed.

Section 7: Build your player evidence

A coach needs to see how you play. Give them useful evidence without making them work to find it. You don't need a movie trailer. You need accurate information and soccer worth evaluating.

Use the feedback you've already gathered

Use Section 4's match research with us or your club coach. Pick clips that show how you'd handle the job your target team asks of your position. Keep working on the gaps your coach identified.

Keep the profile simple

Usually one page is enough. Put your graduation year, position, school or club and location where they're easy to find. Include jersey information, your contact details and links to video. Label GPA as weighted or unweighted and identify your academic interests if known.

Ask permission before listing a coach as a reference. Use statistics and awards you can support. If the team's stat coverage is poor, say so or leave out the number. An inflated claim isn't helping you.

Use a personal email address you'll keep after graduation. Some school accounts filter outside mail or stop working when you leave. Test yours, check spam and make sure voicemail is set up. Your recruiting conversation shouldn't disappear with your school login.

Make footage easy to watch

A brief identification screen is enough. Put good, relevant clips early. Mark yourself before the play, then get the marker out of the way. Leave enough action before and after the moment to show the decision.

For a field player, show more than goals or tackles. Include receiving under pressure, movement and work without the ball where the camera captures it. Goalkeepers should show decisions and distribution as well as saves. Let your position guide the selection.

Three to five minutes is a reasonable starting point, not a rule. Follow a coach's requested format. Music and effects are optional. Clear soccer matters more.

Also provide a full match with date, opponent and jersey number. Coaches may want to see what happens between the highlights. Use footage you have permission to share. Hudl or Veo links may be practical if that's where your team's footage lives, but test access from a signed-out browser. A link requiring the coach to request permission is a problem you can solve before sending it.

Being seen takes a plan

Wisconsin boys high school soccer runs in the fall. College men's teams are playing their own season then, too. Don't count on college staff making it to our HHS games. They're busy coaching, traveling and preparing their own teams. High school film matters, but club soccer gives you chances to be seen outside that overlap. [WIAA boys soccer schedule](#), [NCAA men's soccer season](#).

MLS NEXT and ECNL are major places to look for club exposure, especially if D1 is your goal. They offer organized events and ways for college staff to find players and footage. D2 and D3 coaches also recruit beyond

those leagues, including regional and state club competition. The league name alone doesn't tell you who'll watch you. Check the actual event's attending coaches. [MLS NEXT's 2026-27 season](#), [ECNL's college scouting and video access](#).

My advice: if you want to play beyond high school, aim for the highest club level you can realistically reach. Better training and stronger competition can be worth getting fewer match minutes. Those teams can also give you more chances to be seen. But ask what your role would actually be. Training with a strong group is one thing; barely training or playing is another. Talk it through with us and your family, including cost and travel. A top club's name won't make up for a poor development situation.

Attendance at a showcase doesn't mean anyone watched you. Send relevant coaches your schedule when permitted and ask what they need to evaluate. Include field, kickoff time and jersey information, then correct changes.

If you mainly play high school soccer, film and direct contact become especially important. Your coach may help with a recommendation or a conversation. That help works best when they can explain your level honestly.

Keep developing

Work with your coach on specific weaknesses and revisit progress. Sending more emails is easier than improving a weak first touch, but the first touch may be what changes your opportunities.

Use qualified coaching for physical preparation and recovery. The goal is to improve and stay healthy, not copy a workout because a college player posted it.

Google It Tip

Find full matches at your target programs and watch the role you'd compete for. Check your own video links on a different device. A coach should be able to open the footage and identify you without extra instructions.

AI Tool Tip

Here is my profile and clip list: [paste]. I'm a [year] [position]. Tighten the profile, flag unsupported claims and label GPA correctly. Sort clips by what they show about my role, including off-ball work. Suggest which should come first. If you can't view footage, work only from the log and say so. Keep it sounding like me; leave ability evaluation to my coach.

Go see for yourself

Watch a college match with your coach if possible. Ask them to point out what you're ready for and what would be an adjustment. That conversation is worth more than an automated "great fit" message.

Section 8: Contact coaches authentically

Players, this is your conversation. Your parents can help you prepare. They shouldn't have to impersonate you to keep it going.

You don't need to sound like a professional salesperson. Tell the coach who you are, why the school interests you and where they can watch you. Then ask a useful question.

Look before you write

At least read the school's website, staff page and roster. Know something about the academic program and the team. If your only reason is "I want to play college soccer," you haven't explained why this school belongs on your list.

Before every email, confirm the coach's name, current role and email address on the school's official men's soccer staff page or athletics directory, even if you found the contact in our spreadsheet.

Coaches change jobs, and a contact that was correct when we checked it can become outdated. If the school doesn't publish an address, use its recruiting questionnaire or ask the athletics office for the appropriate contact. Don't guess an email address.

Sending to a former coach, using the wrong name or referring to the wrong program can make you look unprepared and keep your message from reaching the staff you want to contact. Take a few minutes to check the recipient and personalize your message before you send it.

Fill out the recruiting questionnaire if the program has one. That supplies information, not evidence of an offer.

Send a message that sounds like you

Use a subject line with graduation year, name and position. A short message with working links is fine. Here's a starting point, not a letter to copy unchanged:

Subject: [Year] [Name], [position], [school/club] Coach [Name], I'm [name], a [year] [position] at [school/club] in [location]. I'm interested in [college] because [something you actually researched about the school]. [A genuine soccer connection, if you've got one.] My [weighted/unweighted] GPA is [GPA], and I'm considering [academic interest]. Here are my profile and video: [links]. My coach [name] is available as a reference at [contact shared with permission]. Are you recruiting my position for [entering year], and what would you need to evaluate me? Thank you, [name and contact]

Being undecided about a major is fine. Pretending to love one because the school offers it isn't necessary. Reusing your basic information is sensible. Copying the same flattery to a hundred coaches isn't research.

AI can help, but it can't be interested for you

I like AI. I also want you to sound like yourself when the coach calls. Write a rough version first and use AI to organize or shorten it. Read the result aloud. Could you explain every sentence?

If the email sounds like a marketing department wrote it, simplify it. A genuine reason and a direct question are plenty. The coach needs to get to know you, not your prompt.

Follow up without chasing forever

A brief follow-up after a week or two can be reasonable when a response is permitted. That's advice, not a rule. Consider the season and any timeline the coach gave you.

Reference your earlier message and include a real update if you've got one. New footage or a corrected match schedule can be useful. You don't need to invent news every few days.

Coach [Name], I'm following up about your [year] recruiting class. [Useful update, if any.] My video is here: [link]. Are you still considering players at [position], or is there another step you'd recommend? Thank you, [name].

After a couple of unanswered attempts, put your effort into other schools. You can share a meaningful update later. Your process can't depend on one person eventually answering.

Yes, coaches can ghost you

Some will never respond. Others may talk with you for weeks, fill your position and stop communicating. I'd like to tell you every adult professional closes the loop. That's not something you should count on.

Silence is frustrating, but it doesn't tell you exactly why the conversation ended. Ask once whether you're still being considered and what timeline applies. Then keep your other options moving. A friendly conversation isn't a spot held for you.

Be ready to talk

Know your schedule and write down questions before a call. Be ready to discuss your school interests and what you're working to improve. If you don't know an answer, say you'll check.

Ask what the coach has evaluated. When the conversation becomes serious, clarify the role and next steps. You're allowed to ask questions. Parents can join a planned cost discussion, but the player should explain their own goals.

Afterward, send a short thank-you and record what was actually agreed. "Coach asked for a full match" is useful. "Coach sounded excited, so I'll start" is a guess.

Your behavior is part of the introduction

Look at your public posts and how you speak about teammates, opponents and officials. Parents, your conduct matters too. Assume a coach could see what either of you puts online or does on the sideline. You don't need an artificial personality. You do need to show that people can work with you when the game isn't going your way.

School and verified contact	Last exchange	What was established?	Next action and date
[School / coach]	[Date and method]	[Evaluation, request, offer or silence]	[Who does what]

Google It Tip

Check the current staff page and questionnaire. Read the actual major information. Recheck school names and links before sending. Use a personal email you'll keep after graduation.

AI Tool Tip

Edit this email I wrote to [school]: [paste]. My real reasons are [reasons]. Keep it short and sounding like me. Make graduation year, position and video easy to find. Flag generic praise, unsupported claims and details to check. Show the changes for my review. I'll send it myself.

Go see for yourself

When a coach offers a permitted conversation, take it. A real exchange helps you judge the relationship in a way an email template can't.

Section 9: Evaluate interest, camps and visits

Section 2 explains the difference between promotion and meaningful interest. Keep that in mind here. Being invited to spend money isn't the same as being evaluated for a place on the team.

I want camps and visits to answer questions. You should know why you're going before the family pays for the trip.

Make the camp earn its place in your plan

An ID camp can help a coach evaluate players. It can also be a business. Both can be true at once.

Ask who will actually coach and evaluate your group. A school logo isn't confirmation its head coach will watch you. Find out how many players attend, how much match time you get and how goalkeepers are handled if that applies.

If a particular school matters, ask its coach whether they've seen your footage and whether they need your position and class. Would this camp help them evaluate you? Is there a better next step?

Read cancellation terms and add travel, lodging and meals to the registration price. A distant camp at a school you wouldn't attend needs a better reason than an enthusiastic email.

A camp can still be worthwhile for development or a useful assessment. Be clear about that purpose. It doesn't need to end with an offer to be valuable, but more registrations don't automatically mean more opportunity.

Section 2 covers paid recruiting services. The same question applies to camps: what useful work does the purchase provide, and is the encouragement based on an actual assessment?

Visit as a student, too

Check Section 6 before arranging athletics activities. Confirm what the school pays and what your family pays. An official visit doesn't necessarily cover every expense.

Go while classes are in session if practical. Meet the department, see actual housing and spend time away from the tour. Eat a meal. Notice the surrounding area. Could you see yourself there on an ordinary Tuesday?

Talk with players in your intended major. Ask about travel and required classes. Meet nonstarters as well as starters. Use Section 4's research to ask about real experiences rather than repeating the brochure.

Watch training or a match when possible. Compare what you see with the full-match footage you researched. Ask what your role would require if the team's style differs from your club's. Notice how the staff responds when a player makes a mistake.

Ask about support before you need it

Find out who provides athletic training and how players get treatment. Ask how medical insurance and injury bills are handled, including what the family must carry or pay. Get the answer from the appropriate office rather than assuming all soccer-related costs are covered.

Ask about mental-health resources and whether they're accessible around training and travel. Also ask what happens when a player needs academic help. You're looking for a school that can support you as a person, not only when you're available for the lineup.

Leave with answers, not just a good feeling

Bring the questions you still haven't answered in Section 4. Don't restart the whole interview. Ask what the coach still needs to see and what happens next.

Afterward, players and parents should write down their impressions separately, then compare. Did you like the school or mostly like being wanted? Keep what you saw separate from what someone promised. Send admissions questions to admissions and money questions to financial aid.

Google It Tip

Check the official camp page, named staff and refund terms. Before a visit, read department requirements and reserve results. Put the unanswered questions on your phone or a sheet you can bring along.

AI Tool Tip

I was invited to [camp]. My targets are [schools], I'm a [year] [position], and our total budget is [amount]. From official pages, check who evaluates, participant numbers, match play, cost and refunds. Mark staff unconfirmed if only logos appear. Estimate travel separately. What should I ask the target coach before paying?

Go see for yourself

If you can visit, spend some of the day without being sold the school. The ordinary experience deserves as much attention as the recruiting meeting.

Section 10: Understand offers and real costs

Take your time with an offer. "We want you here" feels good. It doesn't explain the bill or what happens when you arrive.

I want you to compare actual opportunities, not the largest scholarship number someone puts in a message.

Get clear about the offer

Is it a varsity place, a reserve place or a tryout? What is written and what is still conditional? A roster place does not mean playing time. Use the answers you collected in Section 4 rather than restarting that research after committing.

Ask about deadlines and what happens if you need more time for admission or the aid package. A verbal commitment, an admissions deposit and a signed athletics agreement are different actions. Have the school explain the documents and withdrawal terms before signing. NAIA has no association-wide LOI program, but individual documents still matter. For NJCAA, ask compliance for current agreement and release requirements. [NAIA guidance](#), [NJCAA resources](#).

Understand what the division allows

Program	Athletic aid and roster context
D1 participating in the House settlement	Previous sport-specific scholarship ceiling removed; men's soccer has 28 countable roster places with specified exceptions. Full or partial aid may be offered, but actual funding varies.
D1 not participating	Pre-settlement aid framework remains relevant; men's soccer baseline is 9.9 full-scholarship equivalents. Confirm school status.
D2	Men's soccer maximum is 9.0 full-scholarship equivalents, divisible among players. Funding can be lower.
D3	No athletic scholarships. Ordinary academic and need-based aid may be available.
NAIA	Athletic aid may be available; stacking and academic-aid exemptions have conditions.
Junior college	Confirm governing association, division and covered expenses at that school.

Sources: [NCAA settlement Q&A](#), [D1 roster rules](#), [D1 aid rules for nonparticipating schools](#), [D2 scholarship limits](#), [D3 financial aid rules](#), [NAIA aid guidance](#).

An equivalency is a funding unit equal to a full scholarship. Nine equivalents isn't nine guaranteed full rides or a limit of nine recipients. Awards can be split, and the program may not fund the maximum.

For a walk-on hopeful, the D1 change is also about space. A coach can't assume there's room for unlimited unfunded players. The 28 countable-player limit matters even when you're not asking for money. Some players affected when the new roster rules took effect can stay without counting toward the limit. That's why you may see more than 28 names. It doesn't mean there's another spot for a new recruit.

A D3 school can still offer a good financial package

Don't stop reading at "no athletic scholarships." A private D3 school may offer academic or need-based aid that makes its actual price competitive. It may also remain too expensive. The sticker price and the division don't answer that question.

Ask how merit awards are calculated and renewed. A coach can explain the process, but financial aid should confirm the numbers. D3 merit aid isn't an athletic scholarship under a different name.

What will you really pay?

Start with the complete annual cost for your residency, major and housing. Include tuition, mandatory fees, meals, books and reasonable travel and personal expenses. Ask about insurance, preseason housing and anything missing from the estimate.

Subtract confirmed grants and scholarships. That gives an estimated net price. Loans are not discounts. They change how the bill is paid; they don't lower it. Work-study is earned, not money automatically available for the first payment. [Federal Student Aid: comparing offers](#).

Example annual cost:

Annual item	Amount
Complete estimated cost	\$42,000
Confirmed academic scholarship	-\$10,000
Confirmed athletic scholarship	-\$4,000
Confirmed need-based grant	-\$3,000
Net price	\$25,000
Illustrative proposed loan, separate from discounts	\$5,500
Remaining family payment if that loan is used	\$19,500

The school still costs \$25,000 after gift aid. Part is being borrowed. An aid letter can look generous when it includes loans, so read the lines rather than only the total.

Ask whether awards stack and whether outside scholarships change another award. "We have lots of scholarships" doesn't build a budget.

NIL: real money, but don't build your budget around it

NIL means name, image and likeness. It lets a player earn money from things such as endorsements or merchandise using their identity. It isn't just for the athletes you see on TV, and D3 players can have NIL opportunities too. But having permission to earn money doesn't mean someone will pay you. [NCAA NIL resources](#).

One option you may see is an online shop selling school-branded shirts or jerseys with your name or number. Family and friends get to wear something personal, and you receive a share of the sales. The clothing can be expensive. From your end, it can feel a lot like a personal fundraiser: you share the link and hope people buy. It can put a little money in your pocket, but the sale price isn't what you earn. These shops exist, but don't assume every school offers one or every player makes money. [UW-Madison's licensed NIL merchandise platform](#).

Ask what you earn per item, when you're paid and whether there are fees or required purchases. Check how long the company can use your identity and what happens if you transfer or leave the team. School logos need permission; joining the team doesn't give you the right to print them on your own products. Confirm the school's current policy with compliance. The [UW-Madison NIL policy](#) is a UW-Madison example, not a policy for the entire UW system.

Think about who's buying. If it's mostly your parents, grandparents and friends, the money is still coming from people who already support you. The same can be true of a team fundraiser. There's nothing wrong with that, but don't confuse it with a business paying you because you've reached a new audience. Be thoughtful about how often you're asking the same people to spend money.

Some players can build something bigger. If you're good at creating content, building an audience or selling online, NIL can lead to meaningful money through real business partnerships. You don't have to be the best player on the team to be useful to a company. But it takes work, and being comfortable on social media isn't a guaranteed paycheck. Judge the actual contract and what you're expected to deliver, not somebody else's headline earnings.

Keep possible sales out of your college affordability calculation. NIL income is generally taxable, and reporting requirements depend on your association and division. D1 also has NIL Go reporting rules. Have compliance explain what applies to you before signing. Direct payments from a participating D1 school under the House settlement are another arrangement; don't confuse them with merchandise royalties or assume men's soccer receives them. [NCAA NIL guidance](#).

A strong player may hear about money while a program is trying to keep him. Ask who would pay, what the agreement requires and whether it's a commercial NIL deal or a permitted school payment. A coach saying "we'll find you some NIL money" isn't a written offer. Calling a payment NIL doesn't make it acceptable: third-party NIL can't simply pay you to play for a particular school. Have compliance review the actual arrangement. [NCAA guidance on commercial NIL and pay-for-play](#).

Don't expect college soccer to have the money you hear about in major football and basketball. Those sports drive much of the attention around college sports money, but revenue isn't the same as profit, and the finances vary by school. Other sports can bring in money too. The useful question is what this soccer program actually offers you, in writing. [NCAA athletics financial data](#).

Fundraisers and team trips can add to the bill

Go into these conversations expecting fundraising to come up. Ask what players were expected to sell or raise last season, how often and where the money went. A fundraiser for the team isn't the same as NIL money paid to you. Find out whether there's a target for each player and whether the family is expected to cover any shortfall. Ask a current player how it actually works.

Also ask about trips beyond the normal match schedule, such as a preseason trip or an overseas tour. They can be a great experience and a significant extra cost. Don't assume the school pays, that fundraising covers everything or that every program takes one. Get the last trip's cost per player and the next trip's plan. What does the team cover? What would you pay yourself? Is it optional, and what happens if you can't afford it?

Before committing, ask for a written list of player-paid soccer expenses beyond the published college budget. Include any required team fees and trip payments, then add them to your comparison. A nice scholarship letter doesn't answer those questions.

Look at the whole degree

Find out how long each award lasts and the renewal requirements. Can tuition rise while the award stays fixed? Ask financial aid and compliance about injury, leaving the team, losing a roster place or a coaching change, including applicable protections and appeals.

If the soccer plan involves another year, check the degree and aid for that year. Section 5 explains why an old redshirt assumption may not fit. An extra year of attendance has a cost even if the coach sees a benefit.

Comparison	School A	School B
Degree and expected completion time		
Annual cost and confirmed gift aid		
Net price before borrowing		
Additional player-paid soccer and trip costs		
Fundraising expectations and any family shortfall		
Award duration and renewal conditions		
Family payment and proposed borrowing		
Four-year estimate with stated assumptions		
Extra-year cost, if relevant		
Written soccer opportunity and conditions		

For a junior college transfer plan, include both schools and confirm which credits shorten the remaining degree. Two cheap years aren't a full bachelor's degree comparison.

Wisconsin families: check the regional options

Wisconsin residents should look into Minnesota tuition reciprocity for eligible public institutions. Confirm the current eligibility and application process; don't assume every Minnesota school or program qualifies.

[Wisconsin reciprocity instructions](#).

The Midwest Student Exchange Program also offers discounts at participating institutions, with campus and program conditions. Verify the actual school rather than assuming a statewide discount. [MSEP information, participating institutions](#).

Complete the FAFSA for the correct year where applicable. Some schools also require the CSS Profile or their own forms. Check each school's aid page and deadlines. A net price calculator is useful early; the written offer is what you compare later. [Federal Student Aid](#), [CSS Profile requirements](#).

Have the family conversation

Parents should be involved here. Set a limit and talk about who borrows and repays. Professional soccer isn't a repayment plan.

It's reasonable to ask whether the aid package can be reviewed. Use accurate information and be prepared for an answer of no. Inventing another offer isn't a good way to begin a relationship.

Google It Tip

Find official costs and renewal policies for your situation. Check regional discounts and additional forms. Search the athletics site for "[school] men's soccer fundraiser," "foreign tour" and "NIL policy." An old trip announcement can help you ask questions, but it doesn't establish this year's expenses. Ask financial aid to walk through the written package, including later years.

AI Tool Tip

Compare these anonymized aid offers for [year]. Use official costs for my residency and housing. Show confirmed gift aid and net price; list loans and work-study separately. Estimate four years with stated cost increases and a scenario losing conditional aid. Check official program information for additional player-paid fees, fundraising expectations and team trips. Separate confirmed expenses from unknowns; don't treat missing information as zero cost or assume a previous trip happens every year. Keep projected NIL sales out of the affordability calculation. If I provide an NIL merchandise agreement, identify the payment per sale, fees, payment timing and rights granted, and flag questions for compliance or a qualified adviser rather than deciding whether it's legally acceptable. Link and date your sources. End with questions for financial aid and the coach about missing costs, stacking and renewal.

Go see for yourself

Make time for financial aid during a visit or arrange a call with them. A soccer meeting isn't enough to settle the family budget.

Section 11: Make the decision and prepare

Being recruited feels good. Choosing a college needs a little more distance from that feeling. Go back to the priorities you wrote before a coach started encouraging you.

Choose the opportunity you understand

Does the school fit your education goals? Can the family support the actual cost? Do you understand the soccer role being offered? Which concerns have you resolved, and which are you accepting?

Ask again whether you'd attend without soccer. That question matters because playing time and plans can change. If your overriding goal is to play, be honest about the compromises. Parents and players need to have the same conversation.

Your coach can help judge soccer fit. They can't decide what your family can afford or whether you'll enjoy the school.

Don't mistake a quiet inbox for the end

Programs recruit on different schedules. Highly competitive teams may resolve needs earlier, while other programs still have conversations during senior year. Treat that as a reason to ask about the actual school, not a universal division deadline.

If you're a senior without D1 interest, continuing to wait for D1 may not be a useful plan. It doesn't show that every other pathway is closed. Ask your coach to reassess the list and contact appropriate programs about current needs. D3 can remain worth investigating later in the process; there's still no guarantee a particular roster has room.

Keep some nearby schools in the investigation

You don't have to travel across the country to watch college soccer and ask questions. These are starting points for research, not recommendations that every reader will fit:

School	Official men's soccer information
Lawrence, Appleton	Roster
St. Norbert, De Pere	Program
UW-Green Bay	Program
Ripon	Program
Carroll	Program
Marian	Program
Lakeland	Schedule

School	Official men's soccer information
Concordia Wisconsin	Roster
MSOE	Program
Wisconsin Lutheran	Schedule

Use Section 3's public Wisconsin options too. Confirm current classification and school fit rather than treating proximity as an athletic assessment. Seeing different teams nearby can make your coach's feedback more concrete.

Finish the questions before accepting

Know admission status and the written aid terms. Understand the roster opportunity and conditions. Sections 4, 5 and 10 cover the deeper questions about roles, eligibility and costs.

"We'll figure it out when you arrive" isn't enough for a question the family can't afford to leave open. If something remains uncertain, write it down and decide whether that's acceptable.

An unanswered email is definitely not an offer. Ask for more time if a decision deadline is too early, but wait for an actual extension rather than assuming one.

Accept directly and finish the paperwork

Tell the chosen coach and complete the school's required process. A social-media announcement isn't an application, agreement or deposit. Read the documents with a parent and ask about unclear terms.

Once you understand and accept your obligations, tell the other coaches with whom you had active conversations. Keep it courteous:

Coach [Name], thank you for discussing [school] with me. I've decided to attend [chosen school]. I appreciate your time and wanted to let you know directly. Best wishes for the season. [Name]

If you previously signed an agreement or later change your decision, talk to the school and compliance before assuming you can start over elsewhere.

Prepare for being a student and teammate

Keep grades up and finish transcripts and eligibility tasks. Track housing, orientation and registration. Meet an adviser early if the degree has required sequences.

Confirm arrival dates and medical paperwork through official school channels. Ask what equipment is provided. Follow a sensible preparation plan with qualified coaching. Showing up injured because you tried to win preseason in June doesn't help.

Practice the daily responsibilities too. Sleep, meals, laundry and getting to class will be your job. Know where to get help before a small issue becomes a large one.

The recruiting conversation doesn't end competition for roles. If you play less than expected, ask what improvement would help and when you can review progress. Check whether the development opportunities discussed actually happen. Keep evaluating whether the school serves your goals.

If varsity isn't a good fit, club soccer or another way to stay involved can still be worthwhile. Before transferring, look into credits, cost and eligibility. A new roster doesn't automatically fix the problem.

A planning timeline

Stage	Work worth doing
Early high school	Explore academics, show good habits and get honest soccer feedback.
Sophomore year	Check courses and budget; research schools and collect match footage.
Junior year	Reassess your game, build evidence and pursue permitted conversations.
Senior year	Meet application and aid deadlines; ask about current needs and compare actual offers.
After choosing	Complete school and eligibility tasks; prepare for the actual program.

This is a planning guide. Confirm each school's deadlines and recruiting status instead of trying to force every program onto one schedule.

Google It Tip

Use admitted-student, academic and athletics instructions from your chosen school. Put the real deadlines in one calendar. Verify payment requests through official channels.

AI Tool Tip

Compare my final schools using my priorities and verified offers. Show degree cost, academic fit and soccer role, including what happens if I barely play, change majors or stop playing. Ask about conflicting priorities one question at a time. Don't decide for me or treat an unanswered coach as an offer. List remaining questions for my parents and coach.

Go see for yourself

If possible, revisit the school you're close to choosing. Spend time there without focusing only on soccer. You're about to become a student there, and that part needs to feel right too.

Appendices

Use these when you need them. The AI prompts are included below. The full program and contact directory comes with this guide as a separate appendix so you don't have to scroll through thousands of contacts while reading.

- AI prompt appendix
- Program and coach directory appendix

AI prompt appendix

Copy-and-paste prompts for your college research.

AI is optional. Replace the bracketed fields. Use a tool that can browse the web for anything marked research. If it can't open a page, paste the page text, roster or box score yourself.

Start every chat with this

Paste this once at the top of a new conversation. Every prompt below assumes it.

For this conversation: use current official sources (the school, its athletics site, and the NCAA, NAIA or NJCAA) and give a direct link and date for each fact. If you can't open a page or find something, say so and mark it unknown. Keep verified facts, estimates and your own suggestions clearly separate. Don't predict my recruiting chances, playing time or scholarships, and don't assume athletic aid exists unless I show you a written offer. Ask me for missing information instead of guessing. I won't share identity numbers, passwords or financial records.

Open the important links yourself. A confident answer with no source isn't finished research.

Section 1: Choose a school

School-fit interview

I'm a high school student looking at colleges where I might play men's soccer. Interview me one question at a time about what I want to study, our budget, how far from home I'd go, and what I want from soccer (varsity, reserve or club). Then sort my answers into must-haves, preferences, dealbreakers and unknowns, and point out where they conflict. Flag what my parents or coach need to weigh in on. Don't guess my playing level or suggest schools yet. When we're done, turn it into a one-page worksheet I can share, including whether I'd attend each kind of school without soccer.

Section 2: Select schools

Build a starting list

Help me build a starting list of colleges. I graduate in [year], want to study [interest], will go up to [distance] from home, and my family's budget is [amount per year, with or without loans]. My coach says [feedback, or "not assessed yet"]. I'm open to [varsity/club/both]. Give me a table: school, location, my academic program, soccer options, published cost, and open questions. Explain why each school fits my priorities. Don't call a school affordable based on sticker price or assumed athletic aid.

Read a recruiting message

Here's a recruiting message I got, with my contact info removed: [paste]. Is it general marketing, a camp pitch, an admissions push, or a sign the coach actually evaluated me? Point to the words that show it. Tell me what it does and doesn't show, check that the sender is on the official staff page, and suggest a short reply in my voice asking the most useful next question.

Section 3: Pathways

Compare pathways at real schools

For [schools], confirm which association and division each men's soccer team plays in, whether there's a club team, and what athletic aid that level allows. Note any division change in progress. Give me questions for my coach about fit and for each program about how players earn a role. Don't treat division as a measure of team quality.

Section 4: Research programs

How freshmen actually play

Look at freshmen in [school] men's soccer over the last [3] completed seasons, and note if the head coach changed during that span. From official rosters and season stats, give a table per season: freshmen on the roster, freshmen who appeared, freshmen who started, and their minutes if published. Show counts, not just percentages, and say what you couldn't find. Report match coverage and keep an ongoing season separate from completed seasons. Distinguish roster-listed freshmen from redshirt freshmen where recorded; don't infer age. Missing minutes are unknown, not zero. Break out [my position] if the roster allows it. End with questions for the coach.

Who plays, and where they came from

Using [school]'s official [season] roster bios and season stats, show documented recruitment and playing backgrounds (U.S. high school or club, academy, overseas recruitment, another college), marking the rest unknown. Categories may overlap; explain denominators rather than adding overlapping groups. Compare that with who got starts and minutes, especially at [my position]. Don't guess backgrounds from names or hometowns, and don't connect background to scholarships. How have recent players with a background like mine ([background]) actually been used?

Substitution patterns (paste the box scores)

Here are [3-5] box scores from [school]: [paste or link]. Use recorded entry/exit events to show substitutions at [my position] where supported. If there are no event logs, report appearances or minutes separately; they can't show when substitutions occurred. If a box score doesn't show who replaced whom or what position someone actually played, say so instead of guessing. Summarize any pattern these matches show and how much a sample this small can tell me.

Study playing style

I'm going to watch [school] play [opponents and dates] to understand their style. I play [position], and my club uses me to [role]. Give me a one-page viewing worksheet covering buildup, pressing, transitions and what my position does with and without the ball, with space for timestamps. Tell me honestly whether you can view the video; if not, work only from the notes I send back. Then help me compare their role with mine and list questions for my coach and theirs.

Reserves and redshirts

For [school] men's soccer this season, find the reserve or JV schedule and count games scheduled, played, canceled and still upcoming as of today. Don't assume a game without a result was played. Note anything published about who coaches reserves or how players move up. Then list what I should ask about sitting out and eligibility timing under the current rules for my association and entering year. Check the NCAA D1/D2 age-based model and transition where relevant rather than assuming traditional redshirting preserves a season. Ask how the proposed plan fits my degree timeline and whether any extra year is funded.

Academic fit beyond the brochure

Check [school] for a student interested in [major] who may play soccer. From the catalog and department pages: is there a separate application to the major, are there labs, internships or clinicals that could clash with season travel, and how long does the degree typically take? Give me questions for an academic adviser, including what happens if I change majors.

Section 5: Academics and eligibility

Admission and eligibility checklist

I graduate in [year] and I'm looking at [schools]. Ask about my intended college entry, previous full-time enrollment and any gap year or playing-history issues before applying rules. Make a checklist that keeps admission, my major's requirements, athletic eligibility and scholarship deadlines separate. For each task list the deadline, who's responsible and the source. Note where my NCAA core-course GPA could differ from my transcript GPA. Don't tell me I'm eligible; list what my counselor and each school's compliance office need to confirm.

Junior college transfer plan

I'm thinking about starting at [two-year school] and transferring to [four-year school] for [major]. Ask about my previous enrollment and status before identifying applicable transfer rules. Using both schools' official pages and the destination's association rules, list which credits are confirmed to transfer, which aren't, and what eligibility rules apply to a transfer like me. Mark unconfirmed equivalencies unknown. Give me questions to get answered in writing by both schools before I enroll.

Section 6: Recruiting rules

Check a specific activity

Is a men's soccer coach at [school] allowed to [call me / meet me off campus / talk recruiting at camp / host an official or unofficial visit] on [date]? I graduate high school in [year]. Confirm the program's division, then check that year's official rules and recruiting calendar, including dead periods. Cite the specific rule or calendar page, and show me if sources disagree. Give me a one-line question to confirm with the school's compliance office.

Section 7: Player evidence

Tighten a profile and clip list

Here's my player profile draft and a list of my video clips: [paste, without home address or ID numbers]. I'm a [year] [position]. Tighten the profile, flag any stat or claim I should verify, and make sure my GPA says weighted or unweighted. Sort the clips by what they show about my position, including off-the-ball work, and suggest which go first. You can't judge my ability from a list, so don't try. Keep it sounding like me.

Prepare for an honest coach assessment

I'm meeting my [high school/club] coach to get an honest read on my college soccer options. My goals are [goals]. Give me 6-8 specific questions about my strengths, how my game holds up against stronger opponents, and which programs I should look at and why. After I share the feedback, help me turn it into development goals with check-in dates. Don't suggest a division yourself.

Section 8: Contact coaches

Edit my first email

Edit this email I wrote to the coach at [school]: [paste]. My real reasons for this school are [reasons]. Keep it short and sounding like a high school student wrote it, because one did. Make my grad year, position and video link easy to find. Flag generic praise, anything I couldn't explain on a phone call, and any name or detail to double-check on the staff page. Show me the changes; I'll send it myself.

Practice a coach phone call

Play a college men's soccer coach at a [division] school calling me, a [year] [position], for a first conversation. Use plausible practice questions, one at a time, and wait for my answer. This is rehearsal, not a claim about what a particular coach will ask or offer. Don't make it easy. Afterward, tell me where I was vague, what I should have asked, and whether I found out what the coach has actually evaluated.

Decide on a follow-up

Here's my contact history with [school]: [dates and what was said]. I graduate in [year]; my new update is [update or none]. Should I follow up now, wait for a real update, or move on? Keep what the coach actually said separate from what I hoped it meant. If a follow-up makes sense, draft two or three sentences in my voice.

Section 9: Camps and visits

Is this camp worth it?

I was invited to [camp link]. My target schools are [schools], I'm a [year] [position], and we can spend about [budget] total. From the official camp page: who runs and evaluates it, how many players attend, how much match play there's, the full cost and the refund policy. Estimate travel and lodging and show your assumptions. If the page only shows school logos, mark staff attendance unconfirmed. List what I should ask the target coach before paying.

Plan and debrief a visit

I'm visiting [school] on [date]. My priorities are [priorities] and my open questions are [questions]. Build a plan that covers the academic department, real dorms and time off the official tour. Give me questions for starters and for players who don't start, focused on what my research can't answer. Include athletic training, injury bills and insurance responsibilities, and access to mental-health support. Flag anything that needs compliance approval. After the visit I'll send notes; help me separate what I saw, what staff told me and what's verified.

Section 10: Offers and costs

Compare aid offers

Compare these aid offers for [entering year]: [schools, amounts and conditions; no account numbers or tax details]. Using each school's official cost of attendance for my residency and housing, show total cost, confirmed grants and scholarships, and net price. List loans and work-study separately, since they don't lower the cost. Estimate four years with explicit assumptions for tuition changes, plus a version where I lose a conditional award. Include an extra year if the proposed plan needs one. Check regional discounts and additional aid forms without assuming eligibility. Flag missing costs, renewal rules and whether awards stack. End with questions for financial aid.

Understand the soccer offer

Here's what a coach offered me: [summary or text]. Sort out what's actually being offered: varsity roster spot, reserve spot, tryout, admissions help or money. Mark what's written, verbal or conditional. List questions about how long it lasts and what happens with injury, a coaching change, redshirting or leaving the team, and say whether each question goes to the coach, admissions, financial aid or compliance. A roster spot isn't playing time; don't blur them.

Section 11: Decide and prepare

Compare final options

Help me compare my final options: [schools with verified offer and cost summaries]. My original priorities were [priorities]. Show the trade-offs on full-degree cost, academics and soccer role, and how each looks if I barely play, change majors or quit soccer. Ask one question at a time where my priorities conflict. Don't pick for me, and don't count a coach who hasn't answered as an option.

After-acceptance checklist

I'm attending [school] starting [term/year]. Using the school's admitted-student, housing, academic and athletics instructions, build a dated checklist with task, who does it, due date and source link. Keep school tasks and team tasks separate, include final transcripts and eligibility certification, and mark any date you can't find instead of guessing. Draft short thank-you notes I can send personally to other coaches I'd been talking with.

Program and coach directory appendix

The companion file, **Program_and_Coach_Directory_2026.md**, contains the D1, D2, D3, NAIA and junior-college program and contact lists. **College_Soccer_Recruiting_Directory_2026.xlsx** contains the same directory in separate tabs you can filter and edit. Both are included in the recruiting package.

Check the contact's verification date and the school's current official staff page before sending anything. Most D2 through junior-college contacts still need to be checked. An old address or a place in this list doesn't establish a current coach or an active team.